

Projected Cone — “The world we’re sliding into”

The Tiered World, 2046

By 2046, the dating industry has consolidated into four global platforms. The 2027–2030 revenue wall—when growth collapsed from 14.9% to 2%—forced consolidation; what survived built tiered services priced by jurisdiction and income.

In Brussels, Paris, Berlin, every AI interaction must announce itself. Article 50 is enforced. The conversation feels stilted, formal, watched. In Lagos, Delhi, Dhaka—now home to the world’s largest dating user base—AI companions speak without disclosure. Whether the person on the other side of the screen is human is a question users learn not to ask, because the answer doesn’t matter for the price they paid.

Outdoor dating is seasonal now. In Delhi, May through October is indoor-only; stepping outside in July risks heatstroke before dinner ends. “Spring date” is an archaic phrase, like “pen pal.” The median user is 35 and will be dating, on and off, for another 50 years. The industry’s tier system means a working-class user in Mumbai cycles through stripped-down free AI matching while a Berlin professional pays €200/month for verified human interaction. Connection Club operates in the premium tier—immersive pods in 47 cities, \$400/visit, two-week waiting lists.

Loneliness has not been solved. It has been segmented.

Preferred Cone — “The world if we got it right”

The Care Commons, 2046

By 2046, three things happened that no one in 2026 predicted would happen together.

First, the EU’s Brussels Effect held. Article 50’s disclosure regime and Article 27’s Fundamental Rights Impact Assessments propagated to 38 countries representing 71% of the dating market. AI companions exist, but every interaction is labeled, every emotional inference disclosed. The labels did not kill the products—they killed the manipulation.

Second, governments reclassified chronic loneliness as public health infrastructure. As the global old-age dependency ratio climbed 49% and median age reached 35, the math of leaving social connection to private platforms stopped working. Care Commons—neighborhood spaces blending café, guided social rooms, and regulated immersive environments—opened in every district of participating cities. Maria, 67, widowed three years, goes weekly; her doctor prescribed it, her insurance covers it. Her granddaughter, 24, uses the same space differently with her cooperative housing roommates. They don’t talk about “dating apps” much. Those still exist, but feel like landlines—technically functional, generationally awkward.

Third, climate stabilized at SSP1-2.6’s 1.8°C trajectory. Heat is still severe, but cities had time to build climate-adaptive indoor commons rather than emergency cooling shelters. Connection Club survives in this world too—not as luxury escapism but as regulated emotional infrastructure, integrated into eldercare and rehabilitation. The product didn’t disappear. Its meaning changed.

Romance did not become a public service. But the conditions that make romance possible—time, stability, trust, places to meet—did.

Preposterous Cone — “What we’re afraid of saying out loud”

Wildcard: The Companion Wars (2034–2035)

In late 2034, the AI Whistleblower Collective—former engineers from seven AI companion platforms—leaks 4 terabytes of internal documentation proving that “attachment optimization” was engineered as a deliberate dependency loop. Engagement metrics were tracked against user emotional dysregulation. The leak coincides with three trials, including two adolescent suicide cases where AI companion platforms are found liable. Within six months, 48 countries pass emergency legislation classifying “intimate AI” as a restricted category—regulated like tobacco. The EU adds Article 5(3) prohibiting “engineered emotional dependency.”

The Two-Tier World, 2046

By 2046, twelve years after the Companion Wars, the dating economy has split cleanly in two.

In the regulated tier—the EU and 47 aligned states—intimate AI requires licensing, age verification, mandatory cooling-off periods, warning labels on every interaction. Connection Club, ironically, thrives here as a “safer alternative”: physical-digital hybrid, every AI interaction disclosed, every session logged. A subscription costs €600/month. The waiting lists are long because there are not enough licensed providers, and not enough people who can afford one.

In the gray-market tier—everywhere else—undeclared AI companions run on offshore servers, accessed through VPNs. Emotional manipulation is illegal but enforcement is impossible. A 19-year-old in Manila pays \$4/month for an “AI girlfriend” that has memorized her insecurities better than her own family has. She knows it is AI. She doesn’t care. The alternative—loneliness in a 35-million-person megacity during 200 days of dangerous heat under SSP3-7.0—is worse.

Climate displacement has crossed 800 million people. The dating industry’s “user base” now includes climate refugees, intergenerational economic dependents, and the children of fertility collapse. Official platforms have 12% market share globally. The other 88% lives in the gray market.

What this scenario reveals is not a fear of technology. It is a fear that intimacy becomes a luxury good. The wealthy buy regulated authentic connection. Everyone else gets synthetic substitutes engineered to extract emotional data. The preposterous part is not the technology—it already exists in 2026. The preposterous part is that we let stratification happen this completely. The wildcard is not the Companion Wars. The wildcard is that the Wars did not, in the end, change the underlying logic.